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Issue Management

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Issues · Stakeholders · Issue strategies · Issue complexity · Issue expansion

Definition

The field of issue management is of enormous consequences for organizations as they attempt to monitor and deal with the political/social marketplace. It is where surprises often arise, where the rules of the competitive landscape in the economic marketplace are permanently changed and where executives and senior managers are ill equipped to respond. This chapter addresses the different types of issues and the processes by which issues develop, attract adherents and stakeholders, and how they crisscross between the economic and political marketplace. Strategies for dealing with the different types of issues organizations' face are highlighted. Finally, the interplay of issues, managerial discretion, stakeholders, and costs are also addressed. Organizations and individuals need to develop skills far different from that addressed in traditional MBA and undergraduate business programs and where the instruction in strategy and competitive dynamics offer little solace. This chapter attempts to bridge this gap.

Introduction

Organizations, all organizations – corporations, NGO's, not-for-profit, and governmental agencies – want to survive, prosper and grow. It is literally in their DNA, and in order to do so, they must meet the needs of a variety of stakeholders that change in character and in their demands on the organization over time. These stakeholders (customers, clients, investors, donors, employees,

communities, etc.) place constant pressure on the organization to meet their demands. Since the demands are often contradictory and/or exceed the ability of the organization to respond, trade-offs have to be made. The “arena” in which these demands are manifested consists of two distinct, but overlapping markets. The first is the economic marketplace, and the second is the political/social marketplace (sometimes referred to as the marketplace of ideas). We will discuss these two marketplaces in this analysis. It is important to note that it is in the political and social marketplace where issue management is crucial, and it is this marketplace that sets the rules of engagement in the economic marketplace. The political and social marketplace is often the source of surprise and deep impacts on the economic marketplace. We are using the generic term “organization” here as any organization can face challenges in these two different marketplaces. “Organization” includes the corporation. Before we explore these two marketplaces, we need to address issue management (At the end of this chapter is a set of additional reference works dealing with issue management that the practitioner/academic will find worthy of deeper exploration.).

Issue Management

What is issue management? This is not an easily described term, and many authors and researchers have offered their definitions (see, for example, Bigelow, Fahey, & Mahon, 1993; Dawkins & Barker, 2018; Mahon, 1993; Mahon & Waddock, 1992; and Tekin, 2018). Issue management has been defined as “...the process by which the corporation can identify, evaluate and respond to those social and political issues which may impact significantly upon it” (Johnson, 1983: p. 22). Mahon and Wartick (1994) explore the various definitions and approaches to defining what an issue is for an organization (not just a corporation). They came up with a substantial definition that an issue is:

...a controversial inconsistency based on one or more expectational gaps...involving managerial perceptions of changing legitimacy and other stakeholder perceptions of changing cost/benefit

positions that occur within or between views of what is and or/what ought to be performance or stakeholder perceptions of performance and that imply an actual or anticipated resolution that creates significant, identifiable present or future impacts on the organization. (Mahon & Wartick, 1994: 306.)

Expectational Gaps Explained

This definition requires deeper clarification for the reader. An expectational gap is the situation where perceptions and demands on organizational actions and behavior diverge and are based on differing stakeholder views of the corporation (for an interesting view on managing stakeholder perceptions and making trade-off decisions, see Mahon & Wartick, 2012). Zenisek (1979) has developed a typology for understanding expectational gaps. He argues that conceptual gaps form around three types of “incongruences” (his term), which can be easily understood as expectations. The first type of gap is on a difference centered on what “is” – a fact based gap. The second is based on what “is” versus what ought to be – essentially reflecting value choices among the participants. The third is more practical – based on ideals and differences in views as to what ought to be for all – a decidedly policy perspective.

It is important to note that these expectational gaps involve stakeholders and that issue management invariably involves managing and dealing with stakeholders.

Gollner (1983) expands our understanding of expectational gaps, arguing that for a given issue, there is likely to be a perceptual gap and a performance gap simultaneously. The perceptual gap lies in a stakeholder(s) perception of organizational performance and actual performance. The performance gap lies between concerns of actual performance and organizational objectives. Gollner’s work is important, as it allows for the existence of more than one expectational gap occurring simultaneously. Table 1 below provides a visual representation of this discussion.

To provide as much clarity as possible, this suggests that an issue can be argued around the facts of the situation, the values of the situation, and the needed policy or regulations/rules to address the situation and close these gaps. For

Issue Management, Table 1 Issue management types

Issue	GAP	Focus	Example
Type I	What is versus what is	Facts as viewed by different stakeholders	Is a pesticide produced by company A as harmful to human health in Britain as it is in Japan?
Type II	What is versus what ought to be	Conformance or values as viewed by different stakeholders	Should we allow company A to produce the pesticide?
Type III	What ought to be versus what ought to be	General policy requirements/restrictions	Should the criteria for determining hazardous product manufacturing and sale be applied worldwide?

example, an organization could actually change its behavior (e.g., stop selling a product, stop environmental damage, increase philanthropic activities) thereby closing the gap with actual behavior. The organization could also consider, as an alternative, changing stakeholder perceptions of the organization and its actions, thereby closing the gap by altering the stakeholder views. Finally the organization could pursue both changing its behavior and changing the perceptions of the stakeholders. Returning to the facts value distinction noted earlier, consider cloning. Factually we can clone animals, and that has already occurred – so the facts are clear. However, should we clone human beings? That brings us into a value-based argument – is it “right” or moral to allow cloning of human beings? Notwithstanding the facts and value arguments and discussions that could be advanced, should we have a policy to deal with the ability to clone? The point here is that an issue can be argued based on facts, values, policy, or any combination of the three. **A note of caution here:** an organization can have the facts on its side but lose to a stakeholder group putting forward a value-centered argument, and policy can be made even if there is disagreement between proponents of facts or values. Value-based arguments are extremely difficult to manage and respond to as they stakeholders are often unwilling to compromise.

A final example is the corporation Juul, a manufacturer of vaping products. They are under attack at this time for their apparent focus on sales to minors and on potential health impacts. The facts are in dispute with regard to health impacts, and concerns are being raised about the propriety of selling these products to minors.

There are several states in the United States that have banned or severely curtailed the sale of these products. Juul has argued that it is not selling to minors (an attempt to alter the perceptions held by stakeholders), but it is not apparent that Juul has actually changed its behavior – so the expectational gap continues. It is important to note that the challenges to Juul are not arising out of the economic marketplace but from the political and social arena/marketplace.

We have addressed the “what” of an issue, and we will turn our attention to the process by which issues emerge, gain awareness, and support and demand organizational action and response. Before that, we should clarify what we mean by the economic marketplace and the political/social marketplace.

The Economic Marketplace

This is the marketplace or arena in which most organizations engage in on an ongoing basis. This is where competition occurs, where organizations make every attempt to attract customers, donors, supports, and investors. The unit of currency here is money, and metrics of success include, among other measures, sales, sales growth, profits, clients served, donor support, return on investment, stock price, and quality and safety of products goods and services. As such, the issues that arise in this arena deal with the products and services that these organizations provide and their **safety and efficacy**. Organizations have significant experience in dealing in this marketplace and have numerous tools to pursue success – the best known are those associated with the development and execution of strategy. When a dispute arises

the organization is faced with a choice as to where/how to resolve the issue. These arena choices include arbitration, negotiation, judicial or regulatory forums, and legislative solutions at all levels (local, state, national). It is possible that an organization has to deal with an issue in the arena of public opinion (or in the political and social marketplace).

The Political/Social Marketplace

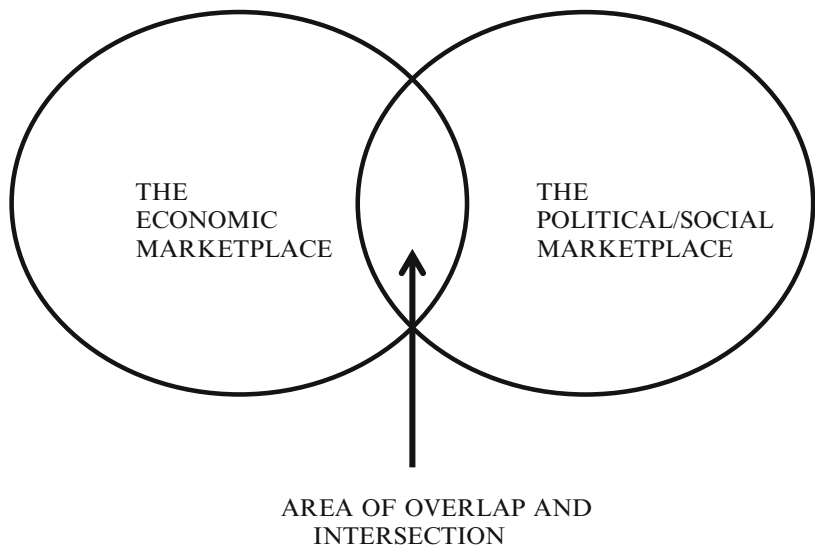
This is the most intriguing and difficult marketplace for organizations to pursue success. A major challenge is in what sub-arena will an issue be introduced and demand resources and attention. Stakeholders can raise an issue in a legislative arena (at any level – state or federal); in a judicial arena (by filing a law suit); in a regulatory arena, before any number of regulatory agencies at the local, state, or federal level; and finally in the court of public opinion – using social media and news outlets to pressure organizations for a response. First mover advantages do exist here, and both the organization and external stakeholders have the option of pursuing an issue in the sub-arena that favors their position and/or aligns with the resources that can be brought to bear on the issue at hand. A quick visual of these two marketplaces is shown above.

It is important to understand that the political/social marketplace is where the rules of competition can be altered – to impact on an entire industry (e.g., the elimination of advertising cigarettes on television and radio) or impact on a segment of an industry (e.g., the difference in federal taxation on beer versus hard alcohol). Executives in organizations are extremely comfortable and well-educated in dealing with issues in the economic marketplace – but their education and experience in dealing with the social/political marketplace is often woefully inadequate. The social/political marketplace is where unexpected challenges arise from unexpected sources and the development of an issue can move very quickly. We now turn our attention to the progression of issues (Fig. 1).

Issue Progression

Normally issues do not arise instantly and spontaneously, but there are exceptions. The recent explosion of the coronavirus worldwide is an example of a non-market-based issue with profound impacts on the economic marketplace. As of the time of this writing, the full economic impacts are not clear – but specific industries (travel and leisure in particular) are being hard hit as travel restrictions take hold. So how does

Issue Management,
Fig. 1 The dual
marketplaces for issues



an issue gain visibility and build momentum that requires managerial action?

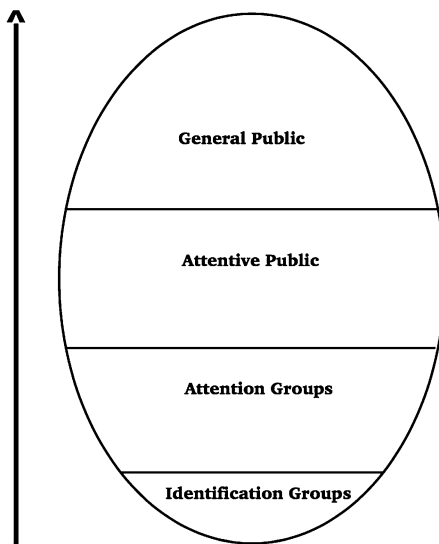
Our first view of how this process unfolds is shown in Fig. 2 below – and the size of each stage reflects increasing involvement of stakeholders and growth and visibility of the issue. An issue begins with discussions among identification groups – this could be a local church group, a group of friends who meet for breakfast once or twice a week, or any informal group that is organized around communities or themes. Most issues never expand beyond this stage, and if an organization is opposed to the issue, this is the ideal place to block the issue from expanding. If an issue has “staying power,” it then expands to attention groups. This set of stakeholders has two important features. First, they are organized around specific issues or concerns, for example, a group for (or against) Brexit, the NAACP, or environmental groups like Greenpeace. These groups are known for their advocacy and involvement with a limited and focused set of concerns. Second they have resources and access to the media to raise the issue to broader audiences and compel organizational response. In addition, they are ideally placed to choose a sub-arena (legislative, judicial, regulatory, social media) to advance their

position. Although by no means ideal, this is the next best spot for an organization to slow, block, or alter the issue and its momentum.

The careful reader may have noted at this point that stakeholders are continually addressed in issue management. An “issue” is a potential demand for action and resolution – but the action and resolution demanded will be driven by the stakeholders that choose to become involved. Consider the issue “law and order” – that is, a very powerful and provocative issue and can generate enormous stakeholder involvement – *but* the issue itself is far too broad to generate solutions and actions, that is, the issue “law and order” needs to be narrowed in its definition and meaning. As the issue is narrowed, stakeholders will enter and leave the contest because some definitions will have no meaning for some stakeholders, but an altered definition of the issue will engage other stakeholders who see the issue as impactful to them.

As “attention groups” become involved, the potential for increased involvement by the attentive public increases dramatically. The attentive public are those individuals (and potential other larger stakeholder groups) who are aware of issue, who can be engaged and contribute to action on the issue. This is where the issue can become more diffuse and more difficult to manage but yet offer opportunities for an organization to sidetrack the issue. For example, consider the issue of marijuana. One view of the issue is that it is a highly dangerous and addictive drug; a different view is that it can be a source of new revenues for governments. It should be clear that those involved with the view that marijuana is a dangerous drug would be very different from those stakeholders who see marijuana as a source of new revenues for governments.

Finally the issue begins to receive the attention of the general public at large, and, as with each successive stage, the involvement of stakeholders, the potential for alterations in issue definition, and demands for action increase exponentially. There are now numerous groups vying for their view of the issue to reign supreme, and organization can find themselves fighting a multi-front war. The next two figures attempt to provide a visualization of this



A Proposed Route for the Expansion of an Issue

Issue Management, Fig. 2 A proposed route for an expansion of an issue

complexity. Fig. 3 shows the narrowing of choices faced by the organization – as the issue begins to emerge, the organization (or stakeholders) has the opportunity to manage the context (in what sub-arena will the issue be addressed) and the process by which the issue will be resolved. As time marches on, other stakeholders become involved, organizational discretion declines, and the organization may be faced with managing the outcome of a specific issue and implementing responses to that outcome.

Figure 4 below lays out strategies that can be followed by organizations dealing with issues in the political/social marketplace. Notice that in the early stages of an issue, the focus is on containing the issue – this containment can be centered on preventing the issue from becoming more visible, containing the number of stakeholders involved (e.g., this is a complex issue, and only highly qualified individuals [scientists, physicians, etc.] can address this issue) or both. If the issue cannot be contained, then shaping strategies are pursued. This is where the organization attempts to alter the definition of the issue and the focus of the issue to favor specific organizational positions and resource availability. Finally, if containment and shaping strategies fail, the organization is compelled to cope with the resolution of the issue (deal with a change in law or regulations, a judicial decision, of the pressure of social media.) As in Fig. 3, the costs

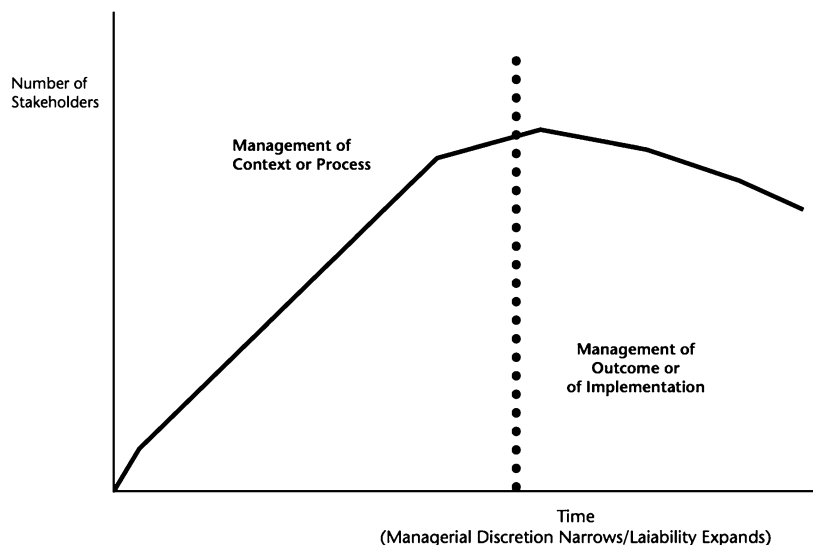
to the organization in dealing with the issue increase, and the ability to shape the issue to meet organizational goals narrows.

But what are the conditions or criteria that could lead to an issue expanding. Consider the following set of criteria: issue specificity and breadth of issue impact, issue complexity, temporal aspects of the issue/emotional content, emergence of an issue champion and media coverage, and existing precedent. Let us look at each of these in turn (Hilgartner and Bosk (1988) offer a different set of criteria that a serious reader should look at and review. They argue that the following criteria should be considered in addressing social problems (issues): the carrying capacity of public institutions, principles of selection, drama, novelty and saturation, culture and politics, organizational characteristics, problem-amplifying and problem-dampening feedback, and communities of operatives.).

Issue Specificity and Breadth of Impact

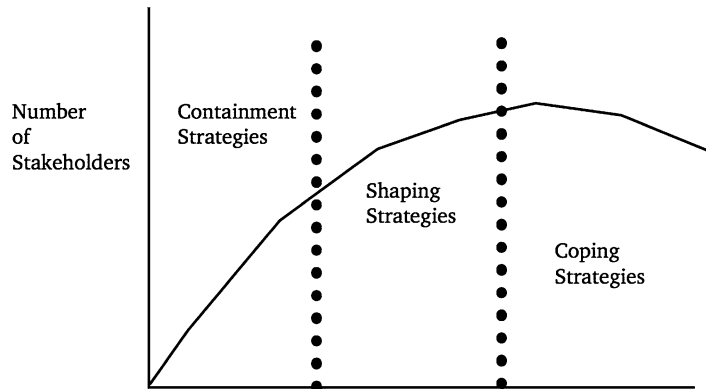
Issue specificity refers to how narrowly defined is the issue and/or how narrow the breadth of impact is on groups in society. Orphan drugs are an example here. Orphan drugs are drugs that remain commercially underdeveloped owing to limited potential for profitability and recovery of investment in research and testing. These drugs are generally associated with incidences of disease

Issue Management,
Fig. 3 The narrowing of
managerial discretion



Issue Management,

Fig. 4 The changing strategic options as an issue unfolds



that are less that impact on less than 200,000 individuals. Although this is clearly a substantive problem and issue, its narrow specificity (less than 200,000) and breadth of impact have impeded the ability of those who wish to see this issue resolved in any sub-agenda in the political/social marketplace.

A more visible example is found in the initial stages of AIDS. When AIDS was thought to be combined to the male homosexual population, it was difficult for those arguing the importance of this issue to gain visibility, support, and action. That is, the issue was confined to a small section of the overall population, and several religious groups (note value orientation here) argued that his was “God’s will to punish deviants.” However, when the virus was found to spread to non-homosexuals via blood transfusions, the issue exploded. It was no longer confined to a small group of people – anyone could be infected. This led to an explosion of funding and new pharmaceutical developments to address AIDS.

Issue Complexity

It is very difficult to raise an issue that is complex. Several years ago, Procter and Gamble entered the feminine hygienic market with a product title “Rely.” Rely was a tampon with super absorbent qualities that allowed the product to provide superior performance and usage for women in their menstrual cycle. Unfortunately because of these very qualities (absorbency and time of usage), a medical condition called toxic shock syndrome resulted in infections that caused serious side effects (up to and including death). The medical complexity of toxic shock was not easily explainable – but those impacted came up with a simple

explanation – “Rely kills women.” This definition of the issue achieved great attention, and when the dust settled, P&G settled over 1000 cases of toxic shock. P&G did mount the largest product recall in history (and their first product recall ever in the history of the company). The point here is that a very complex issue (nuclear power, cloning, climate change, pandemics) is difficult to gain visibility and support unless those stakeholders involved can find a way to reduce the complexity.

Temporal Aspects/Emotional Content

An issue that is considered time-bound will ordinarily not achieve visibility and broad stakeholder support. Normal fluctuations in economies or situations that will resolve themselves with the simple passage of time do not achieve visibility.

However, an issue that has high emotional content is highly likely to achieve visibility and require organizational response.

Issue Champion and Media Coverage

We noted earlier that attention groups were important as they had resources, visibility, credibility, and legitimacy to raise and champion an issue. Another way of identifying these can be seen in the term “issue champion.” An issue champion is an individual or group that continually presses the issue, keeps it visible, and demands action on the issue. Boris Johnson might be considered an issue champion with regard to Brexit. Clearly an important aspect of an issue gaining visibility and expanding to more and more stakeholders is the involvement of the media. The media, which used to be just radio, television, and the press, but has now expanded to social media, can fundamentally

impact the speed and definition of an issue and move it into broad-based public discussion and debate. A useful rubric to consider is that the media loves a story that has the “3 V’s” – victims, visuals, and villains. Any issue (toxic shock, corporate malfeasance, etc.) that has these characteristics has a greatly improved chance of becoming an issue that will demand organizational response and that will explode into the political and social marketplace.

Existing Precedent

One method to derail an issue – or at least slow its progression – is to argue that the issue is really not new and that there are existing precedents or approaches that already deal with and resolve the issue. The ongoing debate in the United States over a constitutional amendment addressing women’s rights has been dismissed because of a precedence argument. Those opposed to this amendment argue that there are existing legislation and constitutional amendments that already address this issue and no further action is required. A corollary to this notion is when an organization argues it cannot respond to an issue because there are other regulations, laws, or rules that prevent a response. In essence, precedence exists that prevents a response. Given all of this, can an organization keep an issue off of an agenda and/or keep it from growing and expanding?

Keeping Issues off the Agenda

Table 2 below is a visual representation of some alternative methods that an organization can pursue to control an issue. Consistent with our discussion so far, the focus can be either on the issue

itself or on the stakeholders (group) championing the issue or both simultaneously.

An organization can choose to mount a direct or indirect attack and/or attack the issue or the group (stakeholders) supporting the issue. Obviously an organization can choose virtually any combination of approaches shown in Table 2. Looking at the column dealing with the issue, an organization using a direct attack will attempt to defuse the issue by engaging in actions that provide an illusion of movement on the issue: a typical example is to set up a committee to look into the issue and report back on results. If nothing else, this action buys the organization time to better respond to the issue and may result in the issue fading from consideration or being overshadowed by other events. For example, when 9–11 occurred in the United States, the Blair Administration in the United Kingdom released news of a potentially damaging nature to the government – but 9–11 took over the news stories and headlines, and other issues were simply crowded out of the public’s perception and view. An indirect mode of attack centers on blurring the issue. Blurring can occur when an organization brings in other stakeholders into the situation. These other stakeholders can provide “cover” for the organization as they can raise other concerns and balance out the views and attacks of other involved stakeholders. Another tactic here is to blur the issue by arguing that the organization would like to respond but cannot because of pressures or demands on the organization by other stakeholders. Employees fighting for increased wages may be resisted because the organization does not have sufficient funds as the costs of meeting environmental regulations are so high, or competition is heavy and costs have to be controlled at this time. An example of blurring an issue can be

Issue Management, Table 2 Strategic options for dealing with an issue

Orientation			
Mode of attack	Direct	Issue	Group
		Defuse the issue For example, set up a special committee to look into the issue	Attack the group For example, question the authority, motives, and legitimacy of group regarding the issue
	Indirect	Blur the issue For example, bring in other stakeholders, add issues, and refine the current issue	Undermine the group For example, co-opt the leadership or bypass the leaders and go directly to membership

found in the ongoing abortion debate. Those opposed to abortion define the issue as murder, a very provocative position and heavily value-laden. Those in favor of abortions define the issue as the right of a woman to choose, another value-laden position and one that taps into the individual rights of a woman to make such a choice. These two definitions do blur positions and attract support from stakeholders and other interested groups. But the very nature of the definitions offered – murder vs. the right to choose – makes it difficult to achieve a compromise on the issue. A more business-oriented issue can be found in ongoing debates in the automotive industry to reduce emissions to improve air quality. This issue, reduce emissions/improve air quality, often gets sidetracked depending on the current competitiveness of the global industry. The argument offered (a blurring of the issue or an attempt to redefine the issue) is what trade-off do we want to be made between high-paying jobs and employment and air quality? The stakeholders concerned with air quality are very different than those concerned with high-paying jobs and employment. As the economy falters, the focus of the issue can shift to employment, and concerns over air quality can be pushed aside.

Looking at the group column in Table 2, we can see that the organization has two alternatives as well. The organization can directly attack the stakeholders, questioning their legitimacy to raise and champion the issue, their motives, and authority. Note that this allows the organization

to avoid dealing with the issue directly but instead shift the focus of the debate and discussion to the “worthiness” of the stakeholders who are advancing the issue. The risk to the organization here is that it can be seen as a “David and Goliath” situation – a large, powerful organization trashing a small stakeholder or individual. In such a case, this approach could easily backfire and increase support for both the issue and the stakeholder (or stakeholders) pressing for action. Finally an organization dealing with an issue could choose instead to undermine the stakeholders supporting the issue. Tactics here include such approaches as bringing in leaders of the opposition into the decision-making of the organization (thereby co-opting them and reducing their independence and ability to speak out on the issue). The other alternative is to bypass the leadership of the stakeholder groups and go with direct appeals to the membership. All of these approaches involve resource costs (time, talent, money) to the organization and are attempts to delay, obfuscate, alter and blur the issue itself, and question the stakeholder’s involvement in the issue. We have noted that dealing with and managing issues involve, of necessity, the management of stakeholders. In the initial emergence of an issue – the focus is on managing the issue and specifically its definition. The definition of an issue, as noted earlier, has an enormous impact on how visible the issue will become and what stakeholders will enter into the contest. In Table 3 below, we try to tie

Issue Management, Table 3 Managing issues and stakeholders

	Issues	Stakeholders
Objective	Minimize surprises, exercise control over societal processes	Appease critical actors, stimulate cooperative processes
What is being managed?	Events, trends, and developments	–
Who is being managed?	–	Individuals, groups, and organizations
Who is managing?	Staff specialists	Boundary spanners
Diagnostic tools	Issue scanning	Stakeholder mapping
Evaluative processes	Issue interpretation, issue categorization, cognitive mapping	Identity analysis, interest analysis, influence analysis
Prescribed responses	Issue advertising; media relations, public relations	Grass roots, charitable contributions, cooptation

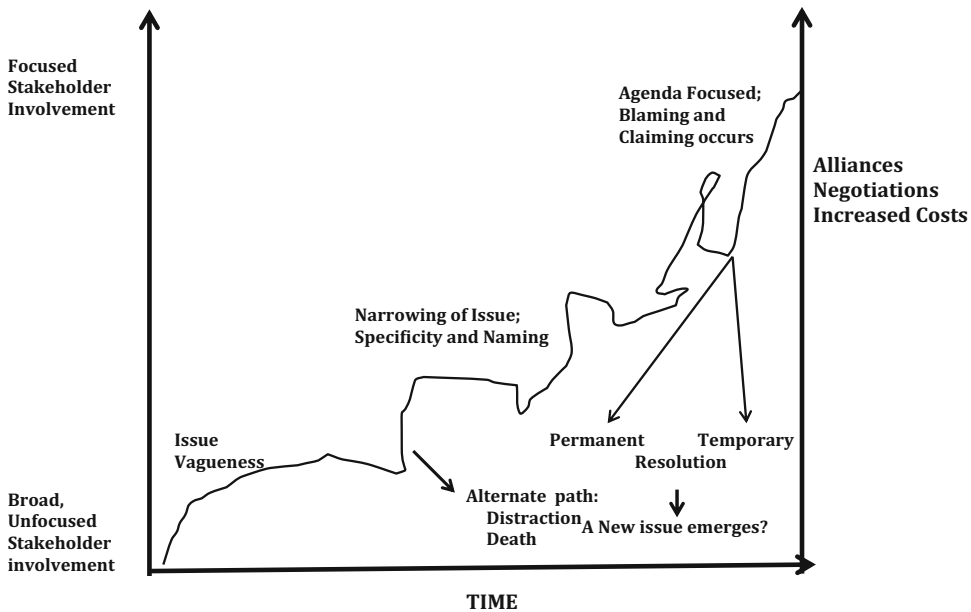
the two themes together – dealing with issues and stakeholders as an iterative ongoing process.

Putting It All Together

We have covered a great deal of ground in addressing what an issue is and how organizations could deal with issues and stakeholders in the political/social marketplace. In this section we will conclude our discussion with a final look at how issues emerge and stakeholders become involved and the costs to the organization over time. Fig. 5, below, lays out this complexity in a visual format. The left vertical scale measures stakeholder involvement from broad and unfocused to a narrower set of stakeholders who are committed to the issue and who are focused laser like on the issue and demand action and ultimate resolution of the issue. The right vertical scale shows the increasing costs to the organization to deal with the issue as it emerges and gains visibility and adherents, becomes more focused, and requires the formation of alliances and negotiations to resolve the issue. The horizontal line on the bottom reflects the passage of time – but note

that the speed with which an issue arises can vary greatly and over the life cycle of an issue there can be times with the issue seems to stall, or go away, only to emerge again at a later date with a new set of stakeholders or a revised definition or as a result of increased/renewed media involvement.

When an issue arises, shown in the lower left hand corner, it is often vague and requires little action other than monitoring the issue to see how it might develop. Stakeholder involvement and media attention are minimal. As time passes, the initial vague issue can merely die from lack of adherents, visibility, and stakeholders or increase in visibility and stakeholder involvement. The squiggly line is meant to represent the fact that issue emergence and development are not linear. A final insight into how issues progress is thru a process of naming, blaming, and claiming (Festiner, Abel, & Sarat (1980–1981). In their work they are focused on the emergence, and transformation of disputes can be described. They start with the crucial role of “naming” a dispute (in our language, an issue), then move to how stakeholders “blame” someone or some organization, and then finally conclude with “claiming” – that is, where the stakeholders after naming the issue



Issue Management, Fig. 5 The complexity of issues, stakeholder management and costs over time

and assigning blame now turn to claiming action and responses from those whom they blamed. They observe: "In order for disputes to emerge and remedial action to be taken, an unperceived injurious experience (unPIE, for short) must be transformed into a perceived injurious experience (PIE)" (1980–1981: 633). They offer the following example to clarify what they mean:

For instance, asbestosis only became an acknowledged "disease" and the basis of a claim for compensation when shipyard workers stopped taking for granted that they would have trouble breathing after ten years of installing insulation and came to view their condition as a problem. (1980–1981: 635)

Once a dispute is "named," then the issue becomes more structured and narrowed and can be advanced by stakeholders interested in a resolution of the problem (Bartha (1983) offers a unique view here – arguing that issues in the initial stages are supported by those most impacted directly by the problem or dispute – and they work to expand the network of stakeholders and thereby raise the issues visibility and impact.). The transformation from naming to blaming is where the stakeholder attributes the injury or problem source to the fault of another individual or social organization or entity. The injured person (or group) feels wronged and believes that something needs to be done in response to this perceived injury. In the asbestos example noted earlier, this transformation occurs when the individuals hold the manufacture of asbestos or the employer responsible for their condition. To be clear, individuals complain about the weather all the time – but no blaming can occur because this situation is so broad and the assignment of blame is not possible. The move from blaming to claiming occurs when the entity or stakeholder is identified and is then asked to provide a remedy of some kind. For example, stakeholders can initially complain that taxes are too high (naming) and then note the federal government should do something about it (blaming) and what the government should do is reduce their taxes (claiming).

Note that the organization can seek to prevent naming where possible, alter the blame (alcohol companies argue that we are not responsible for

drunk drivers – individuals are), or attempt to reduce the claims made on the organization to remedy the problem. It should be clear to the reader that as an issue moves from naming to blaming to claiming, the number of stakeholders involved changes, and the demands for remedies and action becomes more specific – all of which leads to increased costs for the organization.

Ultimately the issue reaches a stage where some sort of resolution occurs. This resolution can be permanent – eliminating the problems that ignited the issue in the first place (e.g., withdrawal of a dangerous product such as Rely) – or the resolution might be temporary for a variety of reasons, suggesting that the issue will need to be revisited. In our earlier example of AIDS, the "solution" was to avoid homosexual relationships – but his solution proved to be temporary as the virus was transferrable via blood transfusion to non-homosexuals – thereby triggering a new approach to a solution.

Finally, the "solution" to a given issue can have unintended consequences and result in a brand new issue arising. For example, the banning of cigarette advertising provided an enormous profit advantage to the industry as a whole as advertising budgets collapsed, but revenues did not. Many of the existing tobacco companies then invested in alcohol firms, increasing the use of alcohol and the attendant problems with excessive drinking.

Conclusion

The field of issue management is of enormous consequence for organizations as they attempt to monitor and deal with the political/social marketplace. It is where surprises often arise, where the rules of the competitive landscape in the economic marketplace are changed and where executives and senior managers are ill-equipped to respond. Organizations and individuals need to develop skills far different from that addressed in traditional MBA and undergraduate business programs and where the instruction in strategy and competitive dynamics offer little solace.

Cross-References

- Corporate Political Activity
- Crisis Management
- Enron and its Implications
- Idea of Propaganda
- Interest Groups and Agenda-Setting
- Lobbying
- Media Agenda Setting
- Nonmarket Strategy
- Stakeholder Management (SM)

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Issue Networks

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Keywords

Issue networks · Policy-making · Iron triangles · Interest groups · Policy networks

Definition

Hugh Heclo's concept of issue networks has been highly influential in political science. It designates actor constellations that comprise a large number of participants with quite variable degrees of mutual commitment or of dependence on others in their environment. Responding to the rise of social movement and civil society organizations as well as the increasing number of public policies in the United States since the 1960s, Heclo's concept challenged established understandings of public policy-making that stressed rather stable relations among small sets of actors. While it was later criticized for singling out rather specific actor constellations Heclo's conceptual innovation highlighted important developments in American politics and connected them to fundamental political science questions about the workings of the American democracy, forming a milestone in the evolving research on policy networks in public policy-making and the complex modes of governance in representative democracies.

Introduction

Hugh Heclo developed the concept of issue networks in the second half of the 1970s. Since then, it has been highly influential in studies on American government, policy studies, and in the interest group literature. It stresses not only the importance of distinct issues for politics and the relevance of fluid networks in public-policy